



**Mother and baby homes (including
pre-1948 Workhouses) and
Magdalene laundries oral history
project**

Interview with HT

HT (accompanied for the interview by his wife X)

Location: HT's home

Interviewer: Ida Milne

Date: 18 June 2018

Transcribed by Ida Milne and Olivia Dee

The testimony offered by HT focuses on the experience of his mother who spent over 25 years working in one of the Good Shepherd operated laundries in Northern Ireland. He explained his frustration about the lack of information he received about why she was there and other details of her life and death. Along with several siblings, HT was sent to a children's home run by the Sisters of Nazareth. He describes the prejudice and ill-treatment he received as a child because his mother was in a Magdalene laundry: he was told she was 'a mortal sinner' and believed that, for this reason, he was given the worst chores in the children's home (such as cleaning the communal toilets). As an adult, HT began piecing together small elements of his mother's personal history and discovered her grave, which bore an incorrect name, at the local cemetery. He expressed his upset that he spent his childhood in an institution that was in close proximity to the Good Shepherd laundry where his mother was working but was never made aware that she was so close.

Locations and names of individuals have been redacted. Where this is the case is marked by **. HT's wife made some contributions to the interview but we do not have her consent to include them on the transcript. Removing her contributions

meant also editing some of HT's verbatim testimony. Where necessary we have summarised the points he made.

IM: Mother and Baby Homes and Magdalen Laundries investigation. I am at a house outside *location redacted* and it's 8th June 2018. I'm with two people who are going to tell me about their personal experience with adoption and with their mother's experience of the mother and baby homes. Is that correct?

HT: Yes

IM: So perhaps you'd just like to tell me about your mother first and-

HT: My name is [gives full name], just in case you need to know who is talking. Well ... I don't know where to start, do you want me to start about my mother first, or about myself first?

IM: Maybe talk about yourself first then, or how you-

HT: Well I was the youngest of four children, my mother had me in 195*. I've heard, heard what the story happened. I was in *name redacted* hospital and my mother was already in the Good Shepherd home, so I don't know whether they took her out to have the baby in hospital there, or have it there, but I think I was

in *name redacted* anyway. And we grew up in *name of children's home run by the Sisters of Nazareth*, me and my brother M and my sister B was in *another home run by the Sisters of Nazareth*. And I have since learned I have another brother, J, who wasn't in any Catholic home, he was, another story. He was left at my mother's farm place, home place, with an uncle *name redacted*. J was nine at the time, my sister B was six, another brother M was three so then I was just born. And, I speak [now] to my eldest brother J - I never knew him [when growing up] and I didn't know M was my brother [also] or B was my sister, until about nine or ten. But, I lived with M up to then, and he was just a boy called *surname redacted* [the same] as me (2.16). But when I found out about J he told me a story that he was nine, and one day his sister and my brother M, he would, my brother M disappeared, and he says, I wasn't born, so he did not know me, it was just M and B and they weren't there. But he was left on the farm with uncle, and the uncle looked after him for a while and he was there, and the mother never come back so. He says, what did he say, he says then the uncle got sick, a while later; after a while. And he was there in the house, there was no dinner and the uncle was in hospital, and he was left on his own. And they didn't have...

IM: How old would he have been then?

HT: Nine. It was around about nine, and he didn't know what to do, he had no money, and he was just left on his own. So, he went up to a neighbour up the road and he helped him. So the story short then, he ended up then in a state home, in *name of children's home redacted* but we never knew him then until he was eighteen. So, my mother's brother was in England and came back with his wife. I don't know what the situation was, but he brought J up when J was eighteen.

So I must have been about nine or ten at the time. It was the first time I knew I had a brother J, a sister, B and a brother M, even though M was in the *name of children's home redacted* with me but ...

IM: So, were you living with your adoptive parents at this stage?

HT: No, I wasn't adopted at all.

IM: Oh you weren't adopted, sorry.

HT: No, so that's what I am saying I wasn't adopted, but my mother wouldn't sign to get you adopted. So, I was born and I was left in *name redacted* hospital for a month-

IM: After you were born?

HT: After I was born. I've no record of why I was in there, you don't know anything, they tell you ... Then I found out I was sent to *baby home in Republic of Ireland*.

IM: And that's the ... baby home?

HT: Baby home. And in the meantime, my mother was in the laundry. So, to cut a long story short then, we left the home in whatever, but there's a home in *name redacted*, and I got through life and I met X and we were getting married. So I had to go back to *name of children's home redacted* to find out birth certificates and you know so they can see you were christened and [let you] get married. So, I asked the nun in the end, about my mother, and she says "Oh you don't need to know anything". So that was alright, and I got the letter from her [the nun], that my sister sent in 1971. ...

IM: [providing context] HT got the letter sent to him by his sister in 1971 only in 1977.

HT: So we tried to find out about me mother and "Oh you don't need to know anything" [said the nun].

IM: So, you went into the convent, in to the ...

HT: Up to the Nazareth nuns, and they wouldn't tell you anything. So, they said 'you don't need to know', and that put a stall on that. So, we just got on with our lives again, and ...

IM: How did you feel about that?

HT: Very insulted, when I think back.¹ Well they were a figure of authority you see so like we didn't know to question. Nowadays like a what, say hindsight's different. We were institutionalised at the time, so what they says-

IM: Yep.

HT: Like I always say, when we were in *name of the home redacted* we didn't have a conversation with the nuns, we were just told what to do by the nuns. So, like, there's a big difference, there were telling you, you didn't question or have a conversation with them.

IM: Tell me, when you are going to ask that question, was it actually hard to get brave enough to do it? Or was it something that seemed natural?

HT: [ponderingly] No..... I just wanted to find out about my mother. It affected you, that "you don't need to know" [reply from the nun]. That just put you down and just affected then, like, your confidence then in asking ... 'you don't need to know'. And then there must be a reason behind that, why do you not need to know? Maybe you *don't* want to know, so that that was alright.

¹ HT was twenty years old at this point.

IM: So, did it make you worry whether there was something worse?

HT: Aw it got you. Growing up, she [a nun in the children's home] says. 'Your mother was a mortal sinner'. And anything bad you done, you were like your mother, or your father, like. You know?

IM: You were told this in the home?

HT: Aw, yes. Aw yes.

IM: By the nuns?

HT: Yes, oh aye. Yes, that's what they [he was referring, at this point, to a priest that visited the children's home] called you 'Spawn of the Devil.' But the nuns just called you mortal sinners, you know as far as I concerned they can-

[At this point HT's wife suggested that he should talk about the work he had to do in the children's home. In her view, he was given the dirtiest and most unpleasant tasks because his mother was in a Good Shepherd St Mary's home/laundry]

HT: My jobs were-

IM: So the jobs you got depended on who they thought you were?

HT: My job were clean out the toilets, for about maybe fifty or sixty boys, and they were disgusting. And I was only young ...

IM: When you were a child?

HT: Aha, yes.

IM: Like seven/ eight years of age or-

HT: Well about eight, nine, ten, going on up you know. Oh aye. Then, you know, you get up there, six o'clock to say seven o'clock mass, and the priest, we had a priest come out from outside, from a college or somewhere, every morning. So, you'd be standing at the altar faint with hunger, and that was alright. And the next, after mass you were sent down to the kitchen, and you got up a tray. On it was what looked like a big half an orange, but I know now it was a grapefruit or something, and a big tray with a fry and porridge and stuff. So he was getting toast cut in triangles and butter squares. And-

IM: And what did you get?

HT: I got looking at it. So we, that's what I'm saying, so we go back in and we were lucky if we got lumpy porridge or something then when we went over. But, I talked about it to some boy and he said he'd have ate it. Sure I was institutionalised, I never thought to do something like that. You think so 'I'm going to go hungry.' So whenever the nun said 'you don't need to know', well that's, you don't need to know, you were just told that, because that's what, that's the way you were brought up like that. So.

IM: and it's also something of the times, too?

HT: I feel like that time you don't know, you are just doing it because you had to clean the chapels, clean the nuns' cells, and then, that's when you come home [from school]. In the morning, after Mass, and you didn't do Mass every day, but you had your turn, like there was always a group of people doing it. And then, in the morning you'd bring, you'd get the breakfast, and then you had to wash the dishes. They were chores, like you know, wash the dishes, make the beds and then after that I had to clean the toilets but I'd go back there and talked about it [and other former residents told HT], 'I never had to do that.' Half of them never had to do work, and I'm going ... I didn't realise I was doing more than the others, because you were busy working.

[This work continued when the children went away holidays]

HT:[On holidays] there was a big bucket ...

IM: So when you go, when you say on holidays, like go to the seaside somewhere or something?

HT: Aye, well later on when we were older we went to a house down in Donegal, but there were no toilets, so there was a big tin, with a toilet lid on it. And, of course I got that job again, of emptying the shit and ... every morning.

IM: So you'd be doing all these jobs while going, first of all, to national school, or ...?

HT: Primary school and then secondary school. So then when you came home then like you say, you'd go down clean the chapel, and out where the nuns lived, down to their cells. What they called their cells. Just wee bedrooms. Weren't actually prison cells or nothing. That's what your job was then. You had to clean up at night as well then, after the dinner. You know, so most of the work was done by the boys. Any work, cleaning, sweeping, whatever. So like, there was nothing done by the nuns. There was only a couple of nuns there to do, so they couldn't do it anyway, so we were kind of running the place under their instructions, you know. So that's what happened in *name of children's home redacted*. But, I feel looking back, now, I feel they treated me like dirt because ... I didn't ... I was getting treated like dirt.

IM: It was just normal life to you?

HT: That's right, yeh, So I didn't know I was treated like dirt, but I look back now I think I was treated like dirt.

IM: and can you see other people who did lesser...

HT: Oh, aye, and got better treated. Say, I never got that, you know.

IM: How many were there?

HT: It was up to sixty people at times, different age groups.

IM: Yes.

HT: It started off at the nursery, and then at five you were put up to the junior dormitory. Once you got to ten or eleven you were in the senior dormitory.

IM: And how many would be in that?

HT: Oh, about twenty or twenty-five, it was just rows and rows of beds, it was ... just like ... one big shed, you know, it was a really big shed.

IM: How did you get out?

HT: When I was fifteen, I was told the nuns want you down in *location redacted*. I thought I was wanted to clean the chapel or something. And there was a minibus, a van, and they said get you in there. So I got in the van, and there was a big long journey. And they took me to *location redacted* to an old peoples' home. I got up there late, and they said, that's your room there. So the next morning they got me up, and said, that's your job. It was an old peoples' home in *location and name redacted*. They said to me, you go in and shave them boys, there. And [gave me] a thing with a wee sharp blade on it. And I said, "I can't shave, I don't even shave myself, how would I shave?" In terms of the job, I was staying the same. Cleaning up after [people], shit and dead bodies and all that. I must have been there about six months, carried out half a dozen bodies, old fellows and old ones and all that. Washing them.

IM: So were you...

HT: There was no laundry up there, just an old people's home, still run by the Nazareth nuns. As far as my mother was concerned, I was going on with my life, I was surviving and all that.

IM: So tell me then, how did you go about finding your mother, after that.

HT: Well in 198* we got a phone call to say my mother was dead.

IM: This was from the nuns? In?

HT: I don't really know who it was to tell you the truth. Aye, she contacted us to say: "The Mass is at the Good Shepherd." So we went up there.

IM: And did you know she was still alive? Did you know where she was?

HT: I had an idea. Aye. My sister knew.²

HT: So whenever I went to the Mass, I met my older brother J for the first time. I did get to meet him [once before] at 18. But I didn't really know him [then]. I

² When HT asked for his birth certificate from the Sisters of Nazareth, aged twenty, he was not told his mother was still alive.

got to talk to him better at the funeral, got to know him and he was able to tell us what happened, and introduce us to P and M. My mother's brother and his wife. And [J] took us out to where that farm was. This was the first time we had heard anything of it, you know, and seen [it]. The farm was outside *location redacted*. A farm of twenty acres. J ended up getting the farm, the land, but eh, as far as [discussing] my mother was concerned, we lost contact again then.

IM: They [HT's aunt and uncle] didn't have children, did they?

HT: I don't know why P didn't get it. That made me think something strange was happening. I got a copy of the will from my uncle. He did not know I was born, so he stated that J and B would get money *after* they leave the institutions, because he copped on. He must have thought the nuns would take the money or something. We lost contact then, and I thought I would see if I could find my mother's grave, because there are three cemeteries [all close to each other]. I was kind of confused, and there was another one further on out, and we couldn't find it. And then a couple of years later we found the grave anyway. The communal grave for the Good Shepherds. And we found others. *Mother's name redacted*, the same date, and my mother was *name redacted* [Note: her surname was different from the surname placed originally on the grave]. So we asked the nuns, and they said "Oh, we made a mistake, with her name. And that's okay". [Then nuns said] they didn't deal with the graveyard [and told us to] go and see the local parish, about who was in charge of the grave. So we went to *name of RC parish redacted*.

IM: That would be the diocese?

HT: The diocese, aye, and we got in touch with somebody, and they said “OK, we will try to sort something out”, and [they] come back later, and they said, “Oh, about the mistake”, they said “it is too expensive to change”. I said “So what can you do?” And they were talking about me doing it, and I said, I couldn’t afford to do it. So we just left it like that until the inquiry started, and I thought, well - the Inquiry for Institutional Abuse - well, I’ll go to a solicitor now, and maybe I will get them to do something. So I went to a solicitor, and he wrote the letter, and we got word back, and went down, and all was changed on the head stone. And so, still no explanation, and started writing letters to the nuns and I have copies here, to give to ye. The letters you see here. I find them very defensive, they didn’t want to know really...

IM: Can I just say that you are happy that we take away copies of these, of the correspondence that you have had? With the Good Shepherd solicitor ... just so I remember, is it the next folder.

HT: Aye. Aye. So I didn’t really know my mother, so I couldn’t tell you about her. I only know of four wains, but when I got the information back from the Family Care Society, they stated she had five children, which was news to me, and confused me as well, so...

IM: Well maybe we will be able to chase that up as well, to see...

HT: Aye.

IM: Do you know was she living on the farm when she had...

HT: Yes she was living on the farm with my uncle, as I say J and M and B were there.

IM: And you think she went in [to the Good Shepherd St Mary's home/laundry] when she had you?

HT: Yes, in their letter they say she chose to go in. There was not any order, you know there was no court order, no social services order. She chose to be there and had a happy life ... so

IM: She was 37?

HT: At the time, and that made me feel she didn't want me, and she was happy to be in there.

IM: That is a very hard thing to know, it would be lovely to find some answer.

HT: I don't believe that at all, they'd tell you anything. I was speaking to another girl - I only found out this morning - she says knows my mother and I only found out that this morning, and didn't get a chat with her to find out what the craic was.

IM: Did she work with her?

HT: She was a... a mother and baby thing as well thing, so she... she would be one of the what do you call, inmates. As well. She wasn't in voluntarily.

IM: So was there any clue from the family if you don't mind me asking, why she went in, [from] your brother or anything?

HT: No, J doesn't know. He was only nine, you see. He was taken away to England with his uncle, P. They were well-to-do, over in England. They had a big house near *redacted*. I don't know why he didn't help his sister. We don't know anything about our parents or anything; our father, if it is all the one father. We know we have the one mother alright, but we don't know about the father's part. It is all a mystery, as well, you know. When you go do down to the local area... I go down to the local area where the farm was, and try to talk to people...Some people tell you stories, they were all telling me about my granny and family and all, but they all kind of clam up...because...it's just...

IM: So you think there is something they are not telling you?

HT: Aye, aye. In the local area. She was there with three wains, and she was away, with three wains, and nobody asked questions, it does not make sense.

IM: So you think they might know something.

HT: Aye, well through passage of time; we did not catch on to this until it was too late.

IM: Yes.

HT: Had we gone down earlier, had I known at the time I got married and all. We could have found out. But the nuns did not want us to get in contact with our mother. I am just assuming now that ,....we were not allowed to be adopted, because she would not sign, and that is why she was kept in there, you know [although]. I am not saying that is a fact, and that is why she was kept in there.

IM: So you think she was not all that willing to be there?

HT: No she wasn't, at all, definitely not. With passage of time, she had no confidence to go out anywhere. That is why I wrote the letter asking what did they do to help her, establish her, and help her family.

IM: And, just for the tape, HT has written a beautiful letter asking the nuns how she was treated and did they know of the kind of impact it had on the family.

HT: Do you want that read out then?

IM: If you want to, do you want to read it.

HT: [nods that IM should read it]

IM: You took me mother when I was born, to give her a good life. You had her for twenty-five years, working in your laundry. She could leave anytime she wanted, you say, but she had nowhere to go with four children taken from her, and no home of her own. What did you do to help her apart from working in your laundry? Did you enable her to find a home and help her to care for her children? Or maybe help her stand alone and help herself. You had her twenty-five years, and I had none. I was told her existence was none of my business so I did not know. She was where she was, she [a mortal sinner] is what you said. So you had her in your laundry, for twenty-five years. When she died, you buried her in a pauper grave, after twenty-five years of working in your laundry, you could not

even put her real name on the headstone. For twenty something years, she was buried with the wrong name. When I discovered where she was buried and questioned why she was buried under a different name [the] Church said it was a mistake. I asked to get her name changed, I was told it would be too expensive. You did not get it changed until a solicitor sent you a letter at our request. You failed our mother when she was alive and, also, in her death. When I learned of her death, after I was born, and even after her death, I was traumatised. You failed her in death, not to mention the effect on her poor children. We were separated to different orphanages, we also had nowhere to go. God helps those who help themselves. You did help yourself.

IM: So that was written, when did you send that?

HT: That was written the year before last ... 2016, the reply I got was from that letter.

IM: From the solicitor in Wicklow?

HT: From the solicitors yes. It was not very informative, it was just to say my mother was happy, to be with us [meaning the Good Shepherds Sisters]. That is the message I took from it, so that does not help me much, either. I was thinking then, I will write this letter.

IM: Did it help?

HT: [very firmly] Yes. These days, as far as I could see, her [children] were not anything to do with them, they [the Good Shepherd Sisters] didn't care, I was just curious about why they didn't care about these mothers, don't you know, all they were interested in was getting a worker, to tell you the truth.

[HT then moved on to discuss his recollection that at the Historical Institutional Abuse Inquiry one of the barristers raised the possibility that his mother continued to work in the Good Shepherd laundry in the belief that this contributed to the upkeep of her children by the Sisters of Nazareth].

HT: Aye. That would go to pay for them uns. So they were [also] making collections, regularly.

IM: And where were they making the collections?

HT: Outside the court. That was new to me too, making them work for a slave to pay for us, and making us look after ourselves, and then they were getting paid by the state, and then they were collecting every month, around the doors ... around the *location of the Good Shepherd St Mary's home where HT's mother was living*.

HT: Oh yes, I found out they were collecting about 2000 quid a month in the sixties, so they were. A good auld scam! Around the doors.

IM: Knocking house to house, locally?

HT: [Addressed to his wife who was sitting in on the interview] You were saying about when you were younger, seeing a nun with a black bag, You know it was a good scam they had. Oh, I had seen a nun going out with a black bag. And when I think we were told our mother was working in the laundry to pay for us ...

IM: Where were your sister and brother, you were saying they were in orphanages ...

HT: She was in *home run by Sisters of Nazareth* and my other brother J ended up in the *names a state run home children's home*. So I didn't ... J is still estranged from us. I still contact him, but there is still a bit of a strange ...

IM: Tension?

HT: Well, I try to talk to him about it, but he was more traumatised than I am, because he was nine. His sister disappeared and his mammy disappeared and his brother, and he was left on his own. Whereas I grew from a blank sheet, from

nothing to knowing nothing, and sure knowing nothing ... nothing worries you, you know until you find out, you know. Just disappeared. That put that in context for me, when my wife said imagine that our disappeared, and their mother disappeared, and the oldest boy is still there. It brought it close to home So I can't really give you anything about my mother, other than these certificates here.

IM: Maybe we will read them out, just so that we know them. So, you have this here, this sheet from the Family Care Society, is it ok if I read that out?

HT: Yeah ok, uh huh.

IM: And it's your background information. *Biographical information redacted*. [Includes information that HT's mother was Roman Catholic. Birth father was not named on his birth certificate. It says HT was discharged from the children's home at sixteen in 197*, which HT corrects as he was discharged from the home aged fifteen.]

IM: And, it's also recorded that you left the children's home and as well as working you were to attend night classes and go for a trade later. So did that happen?

HT: No, well they give us trade yes. I asked a builder for a job when I was there, so I got that myself. And, no I didn't go to any classes cause it was 197*, and I was down *name redacted* College [where] they sent me.

IM: Yeh.

HT: I went down and it was, I had to go past tartan gangs³ and all that, they got in the way of the road, so I thought I'm not going down there again so, I didn't, I didn't know *location redacted*. I was scared, so I didn't bother going. So, it was just the state of it. Took me from *location where he grew up* to the middle of *location redacted*.

IM: Kind of a baptism of fire?

HT: Height of the Troubles. It was kind of confusing for me at the time you know.

IM: Sounds like a second set of trauma.

³ Tartan gangs were a violent part of youth culture in early 1970s Northern Ireland. Membership often overlapped with that of loyalist paramilitary groups.

HT: You didn't know where ... well it was really when you think about it, but you just had to keep your head down. I didn't know where to go or what part of the city to go, where you were safe or not so ...

IM: Did they kind of help you to negotiate or to talk about dealing with the Troubles at all ...

HT: No, no, no, they didn't want to get you out of the home, they wanted to keep you in there longer. Like their plan was, 'cause I had seen it through the boys there. When you were put in that age, you end up in there permanent, as free work, as cheap labour. Cause I seen older boys there from [who had been moved from another children's home], and they're in their thirties and forties working in there and ... but not getting out you know. But no, I think it's what their plan was. [I] just had a bit more gumption to ask about getting a job [outside] like you know. So, it wasn't a job for me because they were expecting you to wash dead bodies and stuff like and I wasn't looking for that at all. Carrying dead bodies out when you're fifteen, on a cloth stretcher, you know. They had a wee morgue in the garden, in the garden and the wee morgue which they used to wash a body down there. Nah. But, I think that's what their attitude was but no [this was not a job for HT].

IM: Did you actually get paid?

HT: I think they give you a fiver but took it off [you] for keep.

IM: Ok.

HT: Aye. So you didn't really get money. So you were getting ...

IM: In theory.

HT: Allegedly.

IM: So then this is, the second sheet from the Family Care Society says HT's mother was born *redacted* and she was admitted into the Good Shepherd Convent in *location redacted*. Thirty-seven years old and that she was admitted in 195*. That she had five children, and this was the bit that was the surprise to you? Because you only knew of four? And that she dies on the *redacted* 198* and is buried in *redacted* cemetery and again this is, I've seen, you've shown me the pictures of her grave with the wrong name on it, and then with the name taken out. Is it on yet?

HT: Yeh, so she got her real name on the headstone but on the other side of the grave. So her real name is on it now.

IM: So she had it taken off in one place and put on in...

HT: They've just taken a band off, and the band of the other one to make it look balanced, chiselled out her false name.

IM: Ok. And then it says after that that she was resident in the Good Shepherd Convent *location redacted* at the time of HT's birth and that your brother M was admitted at the same time as you [to the children's home]. It's recorded that M dies in July 198*. And then there's another page of explanatory notes [on a baby home in the Republic of Ireland where HT spent his early childhood before being transferred to a children's home back in Northern Ireland] So do you think your sister was already transferred then by the time you were born?

HT: Yeh.

IM: So she must...

HT: She would have gone straight [there] She doesn't say anything too bad about the nuns cause they must have treated the girls different to the boys, they didn't like the boys.

IM: Or maybe she didn't become [a] victim of what you met? That they were judging you on what they thought...

HT: Aye, it's hard to know what they were thinking but like you say when you're going through it, growing up in it, you don't know. [HT's sister only found out that M was her brother when she was told to go and clean him up by the nuns.] They got her to clean him up.

IM: So he must have been old enough to be in school though since four or five?

HT: Aye four or five.

IM: And was she nine or so?

HT: She was a few years older, so maybe eight or whatever it is. I dunno what age it...

IM: And does she have any thoughts about what happened?

HT: I was able to get, because I work around *location redacted*, I was able to get more information because I talked to people and I don't worry about what people think about me or where I'm from. So I'm able to say I got a lot of information ... that's where I got a lot of all this information from about me

mother, and then I was able to help B [his sister]. So ...no it's ... I can ... mean ... half a thing about B and help them to clean up M when he dirtied himself, you know.

IM: Even that, that's the way they give out information ... I mean it's one thing to have to clean up a dirty child, I remember having to do it in school too, the big girl with the little girl, and we didn't even have nuns, but you know, to...

HT: That's how she found out, she knew him [M] but that's where we was, cause she'd been separated you know she wouldn't have known, and M he'd have been three. Sure, he wouldn't have known where he was.

IM: And sure he's only a toddler you wouldn't even recognise him.

HT: That's it aye, that's it aye definitely. Cause she did, I must get that letter out if that's any good to you, could you ...

pause whilst interviewee finds a document

IM: Battery's nearly gone, it's gone really low very quickly. I just put in new ones when I came in the door so I'm glad I have this as a second.

HT: This is a letter as I was talking about earlier. It was wrote to me in 1971 but I didn't get it 'til 1977; from my sister.

pause

IM: So, maybe before we'd need to get her permission to record this, but it is a letter from your sister.

HT: She's ask me what I look like

IM: In 1971?

HT: Aye.

IM: And she's writing from *location redacted* where she's a shorthand typist. And she's wondering, oh, are you left school? I'll read out a little bit of it, maybe if I don't identify her that's fine. [The letter asked] what are you working at? [It asks HT to] please answer the letter or get M to answer. [It said] I heard that he [M] was out working what he's doing? Do you both get on well or do you not bother with each other? [The letter continued] I'm sorry I never wrote to you before this as I'm your big sister. I would be anxious to know how you both are doing. When you write to me tell me everything, and if you have a photograph of yourself and M send it as I don't know what you look like now. I'm sure you're

both taller than me. What age are you now? And when are your birthdays? I'm terribly sorry to be asking so many questions but I really want to know how you both are. I hope you're not involved in any of the Troubles.

IM [breaks off to comment]: And again like, you know, that's heart breaking!

IM [continues reading snippets from the letter]: It's really bad now in *location redacted* but it's quite safe where I am now. If you both write, I might be able to come up and see you both and maybe you can come down here for a weekend. I'm living in a flat. [The letter finished with the message] Lots of love from your sister, your big sister.

HT: This dated 1971 but I didn't get that 'til 1977 so she was sitting waiting for me to write back.

IM: Oh gosh and was that sent to you when you left?

HT: They handed it to me [when I went for] the baptismal thing [information]. The day the nun says "you don't need to know about your mother."

IM: So the nuns gave you that [letter]?

HT: Aye they did, but they...

IM: So they'd kept it?

HT: Aye.

IM: And was there anything else with it?

HT: No, that's all they had ... Well there was a gardener up there and he was - my brother then was working on the farm up there and he was staying with the gardener and all. He was *name of gardener - redacted* we called him. He's dead now and ... he had a bonfire going and he said "what's this?" [What was being burned was] all personal information from the mothers to the boys in there [the children's home]. Letters, he grabbed some letters and put out the fire and there was one letter written [from a] mother saying 'here is ten shillings to get shoes for him [a boy in the home].' I'm sorry, you know, the ten shillings was taken out and the letter was getting burnt away so he [the boy it was intended for] never really got it you know? And then there was letters from priests and women saying that the priests were looking [for] money and the nuns send the priests around to the mothers saying you're not paying your money. So they were getting money from all the mothers of the children ... even though they had nothing, you know. So that our *name of gardener redacted* he got that letter and he give it to the boy it was wrote to and the boy was shocked, you know. But all that information's

all getting burnt ... So that letter might have been burnt and I would never have seen it.

IM: Is *name of gardener redacted* still alive?

HT: No, he's long gone. He was an old man.

IM: Do you have any idea what he did with the rest of the letters?

HT: He just give it to whoever ... He just give it to whoever had that name on it.

IM: No hope [that] there'd be another pile anywhere?

HT: No burnt. They're all burnt like.

IM: So you think it was because they were moving?

HT: Aye burnt all the evidence. You see [without] the letter's they've no contact, no reference. If you ask them [referring to the Good Shepherd Sisters] why was

my mother in there - like she wasn't on the court order she wasn't on the social services, she doesn't show up in a taxi [at the Good Shepherd convent] and say "can you take me on?" You know, she wouldn't have even known the place was there. We're [his mother's family] from the middle of nowhere, like, you know.

IM: Tell me, when you tried to get this information from the Family Care [Society] did you have any issue - or did they just reply?

HT: No, that was...

IM: How did you even find out about them?

HT: This was the Inquiry thing [the Historical Institutional Abuse Inquiry]. Inquiry, what do you call it the inquiry? I get confused with the Heaton inquiry, Historical Abuse Inquiry. So when that started I started thinking [it was a] good time to get information. And, you know, it was the best thing happened was where Northern Ireland [unfinished sentence] ... They got a lot of information and people were scared to hide the information because you can go and get it like, you know. So they're all very forthcoming with what they got. Family Care Society [provided information linked to the home HT was placed in]. The Good Shepherds ... they weren't involved, so they didn't want to know, you know? They weren't involved in that inquiry so they didn't give you any information,

very basic like you know.⁴ But apart from that I was able to get all that other stuff to help me.

IM: Another thing I was wondering is when you were in that school were you the only ... was it only people from the homes that were in there or were there other people as well?

HT: The primary school now, what we call outsiders, aye. [The children from outside labelled the boy's from the children's home as the Home Boys].

IM: And were there stigma about them, did people treat you differently because you were...

HT: Oh aye. Aye, well, like we were different, we were two different ... I noticed when I went to *location redacted* you know, the girls would talk to you and chat to you, you know, "where you from?", but then I went back to *location of the home* and they found out where you were from, it was just a different matter. But then, because I knew from my experience in *location redacted*, it was nothing to do with me; it was attitudes towards being a homeboy. But if they didn't like that sure, didn't bother me like, you know. So, I was confident enough in myself.

⁴ The Historical Institutional Abuse Inquiry did examine the issue of children being placed in the Good Shepherd St Mary's institutions although it did not examine the issue of adult women (such as HT's mother) and their life in the St Mary's homes/laundries.

IM: Did you have to kinda be extra good, in a way?

HT: What do you mean?

IM: Did you ever feel the pressure to be, I don't know, a good person?

HT: No.

IM: Because...

HT: We were survivors. We were, we had to survive, when I lived in *location redacted* after, I got a job as an apprentice painter and I was getting £5 a week and me lodgings was £5 a week so I had lodgings [but] I had no money [after paying that]. And then when I, when they put me out I had nowhere to stay so, we didn't, we had no idea of social services, the dole...

IM: How to negotiate everything...

HT: Or anything, so we were just on your own.

IM: The kinds of things you'd learn if you were part of a family.

HT: Aye and a community, didn't know where to go for help. The landlady was having a baby and she wanted the room, and I hadn't a clue where to turn to so I didn't ... I got talking about it with a guy I worked with and he says to me "ah there's an old flat down there". So we ended up squatting, you know, so we were just surviving and a couple of home boys turned up from *name of home redacted*. And, so, I got them a job. We looked after each other. I give him my food in the squat; we lived in the squat. But we weren't angels so there were you can't say we were living extra good now. When I moved back to *location redacted* it was the same, I had to get outta the flat in *location redacted* [because], somebody else wanted it, you know so.

IM: But even within the home did you have to ...

HT: No they tried to make no, no, no we were just all, maybe it's the hard work you know, I don't think I have as bad...

IM: Is there anything else you kinda want to add in or that you think we've missed?

HT: I dunno what kind of information you need.

IM: What's the big question for you?

HT: My question is why she was in there so long. The question that when I wrote was what did they do to help her, I suppose. What was the purpose of the mother and baby home? Was it for the benefit of the nuns to get free work? Cause, they worked in the laundry. It obviously was a business, I was talking to a boy this morning, he was a home boy like us. He's from [name of home redacted] and he was telling me his first job was delivering and collecting laundry for the nuns and collecting the money. I've asked him to have a chat with you but I don't think he wants to tell me. So I think there was a money making exercise. It was a business they were running, really, I don't think it was a charity. What, like, what did they do to help her? Why did they not - with all this building full of women and the only people who seem to be benefitting is the nuns through the labour of the women, rather than helping them to get on their feet. And I don't know how you explain it - whether its social services could establish them in the community and get them more confidence and [help the women from the laundries] run their own lives. You know, why did they have so many people like that? That is my question. You know?

IM: And in terms of social services, did you ever ask them for any details about the Magdalene - I don't know if there's anything they could give you.

HT: No, I don't have much dealing social services at all. When I first come back to *location redacted*, I had nowhere to stay, and I went up along to our chapel and asked a priest and explained my situation: I've nowhere to stay and [I've] come back and he didn't give me any help at all. So [I] went up to the nuns [Sisters of Nazareth] and they didn't give me any help. So I was talking to my brother and he was on the farm up there. He says to me 'there's beds in there, in the pigsty. There'll be beds we used to lie on.' So I says "oh we can take a couple of them". We got a few of them down. That's how we got bedding, for the house, like you know. But I was thinking back and the priest should have put us in contact with the social service or else St Vincent de Paul, like, you know? Cause I always found out that [having] been brought up by nuns and in contact with priests and stuff like that, the only real Christians I ever met were ordinary people out in the street. I come down the first time they [the Sisters of Nazareth] sent me to *location redacted*, to an old people's home, and that was around about September, August, September and when they left me off they said "you can come back for a holiday if you want". So obviously I worked away up to Christmas, and I come back down and the, I was talking to the boys in the home, talking away, and a nun says to me "where you staying the night?" I says "here". [The nun replied] "No, you're not." So, that was alright, after 8 o'clock, there was not train back to *location where he had been sent to begin his adult life*. I was out on the street then, so I just met a boy I used to be in class with and his mother. And they said 'You can lie there and sleep on the sofa'. And then [the woman's sister] says 'I have a bed up there in *nearby location redacted* come on up to me'. So I found they kind of adopted me, you know? She had a big family, but they adopted me as another son and [I was] treated like a brother to the family there. So that's where I found most of the Christians, it was because ordinary people that helped you. But I always find that the religious orders the more I look back on them; that's why I always say God helps those who help themselves, because that's what they done.

IM: And you kind of had this idea that when you came back they would help you?

HT: They told me yes I could stay if ever - it was family ... [but then] you were just sliced off....

IM: And in terms of, if we could find things out for you, what would you most like to find out?

HT: I suppose like my mother, you know, I don't know, I don't really know now. I found a lot of information. I'd try to find out about my parents, my father like, if they had information that she told them. I'm hoping to find out from this new contact I have today, who was in there with her. I didn't get to speak to her properly because there was too many people about. Maybe she's got some information. Just why she was in there so long, from the day I was born to the day she died. That's what annoys me, she was a strong independent, you know. She could have been helped, she needed help and they didn't help did they?

IM: Why didn't they set her up on her own in a house like happened to a lot of people at the time?

HT: I think that, I think that I'm going to repeat myself again, they only helped themselves they didn't help the women and the children of the women. They didn't care about the children, they didn't want to know about us or care about us.

IM: Did you ever think of doing DNA testing?

HT: I would really like to do one of them things, what they called genealogy?

IM: They're actually cheaper, we can talk about this off tape maybe. If there's nothing else immediately for the tape, I, if we can, I'd love to listen, this is a really complicated story and I'd love to listen back to it and kind of, if you like, make sense of it more in my head, and then if there's other questions, or things you want to say that I might come back if that was alright. But see how you feel afterwards ... So we're just going to stop unless there's anything else

HT: No, no. I can't think of anything, that's what I'm saying it doesn't come into your head until after you've stopped.

IM: And sometimes you need a day or two to think about things.

ENDS